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ENHANCE THE QUALITY OF SCHOOL EDUCATION

Improve the quality of school education. A shift from rote learning to an inquiry- and critical thinking-focused system, in line with the National Education Policy 2020, is crucial. The government should implement reforms in governance, curriculum and infrastructure

work. The IITs follow a rigorous and secretive process where only a few people are involved, ensuring high standards and minimal chances of leaks or errors.

By contrast, premier medical colleges have no direct involvement in the setting of NEET papers. "The IIT professors are seasoned experts in their domains and committed to maintaining the standards of their institutes," says a member of the NTA governing body. "Those involved in JEE question-setting lock themselves up and remain out of bounds for everyone. No such thing happens during the preparation of the NEET paper." The member, in fact, reveals how he has often had to shoo away inquisitive coaching centre owners. "I'm not even involved in the setting of questions. If I can be chased, imagine how various vested interest groups, including coaching centre owners and organised paper leak gangs, track those people."

And though the NTA claims it uses statistical and psychometric analyses to detect cheating or questions that do not work, it was not evident in NEET 2024. What does it say about the quality of a question paper when the answer to it hinges on a factual error in a textbook edition? One would not have had this ambiguity, which led to the award of grace marks, if psychometric analysis had indeed been done.

THE TROUBLE WITH NTA

The NTA was modelled on the Educational Testing Service (ETS) of the United States, which administers tests like the Scholastic Assessment Test (SAT), the American College Test (ACT) and the Graduate Record Examinations (GRE). However, unlike the ETS, which has more than 200 permanent staff members, the NTA operates with just over two dozen permanent employees in its Delhi office. It mostly relies on officials on deputation from other government departments and temporary employees on fixed-term contracts. This severe understaffing has led the agency to outsource critical functions such as paper-setting, distribution and data security to private technical service providers and other external experts. For instance, in 2023, it invited proposals for providing outsourced manpower. However, most independent observers say that it is not those who set the papers who are likely to be involved in the leaks. "Usually, it is not the setters who leak papers. This is because multiple paper-setters draw up multiple sets of question papers and just one paper is finally chosen. Leaks happen during transit," says Dr Pravin Shingare, former DMER (director of medical education and research), Maharashtra.

The pen-and-paper nature of the test makes it more susceptible to leaks at the logistical level, either during transit or at the point of examination

R. Subrahmanyam, former secretary to the government of India heading the higher education department, says the NTA was intended to be a lean entity, focusing on online exams with the help of competent technical partners. However, the transition to pen-and-paper tests, such as NEET, added extra pressure. Some previous CBT formats such as UGC-NET have also transitioned to pen-and-paper mode, the rationale being that it will eliminate the need for specialised computer infrastructure at exam centres, avoid network problems, decrease costs and increase the number of centres in remote areas.

However, being a pen-and-paper exam, NEET requires physical storage and transportation of question papers and answer sheets, creating multiple points of vulnerability. Question papers must be securely transported from the printing press to examination centres, and answer sheets must be returned to the NTA for evaluation. Each stage involves several handling points, increasing the risk of unauthorised access and tampering, as highlighted several incidents of malpractice and fraud.

Days before NEET was held on May 5, a masked man in a video claimed that the question papers were likely to be leaked from the printing press. Most insiders, however, assert that it is not the private agencies the NTA enlists who are directly involved in the malpractices. The NTA